

Processing text		
	Processing text in speech or sign	Processing text in writing
B1	Can summarise (in Language B) the main points made in clear, well-structured texts (in Language A) on subjects that are familiar or of personal interest, although lexical limitations cause difficulty with formulation at times. Can summarise simply (in Language B) the main information content of straightforward texts (in Language A) on familiar subjects (e.g. a short record of an interview, magazine article, travel brochure). Can summarise (in Language B) the main points made during a conversation (in Language A) on a subject of personal or current interest, provided people articulated clearly. Can summarise (in Language B) the main points made in long texts delivered orally (in Language A) on topics in their fields of interest, provided they can listen or view several times. Can summarise (in Language B) the main points or events in TV programmes and video clips (in Language A), provided they can view them several times.	Can summarise in writing (in Language B) the main points made in straightforward, informational texts (in Language A) on subjects that are of personal or current interest, provided oral texts are clearly articulated. Can paraphrase short passages in a simple fashion, using the original text wording and ordering.
A2	Can report (in Language B) the main points made in simple TV or radio news items (in Language A) reporting events, sports, accidents, etc., provided the topics concerned are familiar and the delivery is slow and clear. Can report in simple sentences (in Language B) the information contained in clearly structured, short, simple texts (in Language A) that have illustrations or tables. Can summarise (in Language B) the main point(s) in simple, short informational texts (in Language A) on familiar topics.	Can list as a series of bullet points (in Language B) the relevant information contained in short simple texts (in Language A), provided the texts concern concrete, familiar subjects and contain only simple everyday language. Can pick out and reproduce key words and phrases or short sentences from a short text within the learner's limited competence and experience.
A1	Can convey (in Language B) the main point(s) contained in clearly structured, short, simple texts (in Language A), supplementing their limited repertoire with other means (e.g. gestures, drawings, words/signs from other languages) in order to do so. Can convey (in Language B) simple, predictable information given in short, very simple signs and notices, posters and programmes (in Language A).	Can use simple language to convey (in Language B) the main point(s) contained in very short texts (in Language A) on familiar and everyday themes that contain the highest frequency vocabulary, despite errors, the text remains comprehensible. Can copy out short texts in printed or clearly handwritten format.
Pre-A1	No descriptors available	No descriptors available

Translating a written text

Translating a written text in speech or sign is a largely informal activity that is by no means uncommon in everyday personal and professional life. It is the process of spontaneously giving an oral translation of a written text, often a notice, letter, e-mail or other communication. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ providing a rough, approximate translation;
- ▶ capturing the essential information;
- ▶ capturing nuances (higher levels).

Progression up the scale is characterised as follows: the scale moves from rough translation of routine everyday information in simple texts at the lower levels to translation with increasing fluency and accuracy of texts that become increasingly more complex. The distinction between levels A1 to B1 is almost solely the type of texts involved. By B2, the user/learner can provide oral translation of complex texts containing information and arguments on subjects within their fields of professional, academic and personal interest, and at the C levels they can fluently translate complex texts on a wide range of general and specialised subjects, capturing nuances and implications.

“Translating a written text in writing” is by its very nature a more formal process than providing an impromptu oral translation. However, this CEFR descriptor scale is not intended to relate to the activities of professional translators or to their training. Indeed, translating competences are not addressed in the scale. Furthermore, professional translators, like professional interpreters, develop their competences through their career. The language level necessary for a translation also depends on the type of text. Literary translation, for example, requires a level at or above C2. As mentioned when discussing CEFR levels in the section on key aspects of the CEFR, C2 is not the highest definable level of second/foreign language proficiency. It is in fact the middle level of a scale of five levels for literary translation produced in the [PETRA project](#).⁴⁴ On the other hand, plurilingual user/learners with a more modest level of proficiency sometimes find themselves in a situation in which they are asked to provide a written translation of a text in their professional or personal context. Here they are being asked to reproduce the substantive message of the source text, rather than necessarily interpret the style and tone of the original into an appropriate style and tone in the translation, as a professional translator would be expected to do.

In using the descriptors in this scale it is particularly important to specify the languages involved because the scale deliberately does not address the issue of translating into and from the first language. This is partly because of the fact that, for increasing numbers of plurilingual persons, “first language” and “best language” are not always synonymous. What the scale provides is a functional description of the language ability necessary to reproduce a source text in another language. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ comprehensibility of the translation;
- ▶ the extent to which the original formulations and structure (over-)influence the translation, as opposed to the text following relevant conventions in the target language;
- ▶ capturing nuances in the original.

Progression up the scale is shown in a very similar way to the previous scale. At the lower levels, translating involves approximate translations of short texts containing information that is straightforward and familiar, whereas at the higher levels, the source texts become increasingly complex and the translation is more and more accurate and reflective of the original.

In the two scales, Language A and Language B may be different languages, varieties of the same language, registers of the same variety, modalities of the same language or variety, or any combination of the above. However, they may also be identical. In the former case, users should specify the languages/varieties concerned/modalities; in the latter case, users should simply remove the parts in brackets.

Note: As in any case in which mediation across languages is involved, users may wish to complete the descriptor by specifying the languages concerned

44. <https://petra-education.eu/>.

Translating a written text		
	Translating a written text in speech or sign	Translating a written text in writing
C2	Can provide fluent oral translation (into Language B) of abstract texts (written in Language A) on a wide range of subjects of personal, academic and professional interest, successfully conveying evaluative aspects and arguments, including the nuances and implications associated with them.	Can translate (into Language B) technical material outside their field of specialisation (written in Language A), provided subject matter accuracy is checked by a specialist in the field concerned.
C1	Can provide fluent oral translation (into Language B) of complex texts (written in Language A) on a wide range of general and specialised topics, capturing most nuances.	Can translate (into Language B) abstract texts on social, academic and professional subjects in their field (written in Language A), successfully conveying evaluative aspects and arguments, including many of the implications associated with them, though some expression may be over-influenced by the original.
B2	Can provide oral translation (into Language B) of complex texts (written in Language A) containing information and arguments on subjects within their fields of professional, academic and personal interest.	Can produce clearly organised translations (from Language A into Language B) that reflect normal language usage but may be over-influenced by the order, paragraphing, punctuation and particular formulations of the original.
B1	Can provide oral translation (into Language B) of texts (written in Language A) containing information and arguments on subjects within their fields of professional, academic and personal interest, provided they are written in uncomplicated, standard language.	Can produce translations (into Language B) that closely follow the sentence and paragraph structure of the original text (in Language A), conveying the main points of the source text accurately, though the translation may read awkwardly.
	Can provide an approximate oral translation (into Language B) of clear, well-structured informational texts (written in Language A) on subjects that are familiar or of personal interest, although lexical limitations cause difficulty with formulation at times.	Can produce approximate translations (from Language A into Language B) of straightforward, factual texts that are written in uncomplicated, standard language, closely following the structure of the original; although linguistic errors may occur, the translation remains comprehensible.
		Can produce approximate translations (from Language A into Language B) of information contained in short, factual texts written in uncomplicated, standard language; despite errors, the translation remains comprehensible.

Translating a written text		
	Translating a written text in speech or sign	Translating a written text in writing
A2	Can provide an approximate oral translation (into Language B) of short, simple, everyday texts (e.g. brochure entries, notices, instructions, letters or e-mails) (written in Language A).	
	Can provide a simple, rough oral translation (into Language B) of short, simple texts (e.g. notices on familiar subjects) (written in Language A), capturing the most essential point. Can provide a simple, rough oral translation (into Language B) of routine information on familiar everyday subjects that is written in simple sentences (in Language A) (e.g. personal news, short narratives, directions, notices or instructions).	Can use simple language to provide an approximate translation (from Language A into Language B) of very short texts on familiar and everyday themes that contain the highest frequency vocabulary; despite errors, the translation remains comprehensible.
A1	Can provide a simple, rough oral translation (into Language B) of simple everyday words/signs and phrases (written in Language A) that are encountered on signs and notices, posters, programmes, leaflets, etc.	Can, with the help of a dictionary, translate simple words/signs and phrases (from Language A into Language B), but may not always select the appropriate meaning.
Pre-A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>	<i>No descriptors available</i>

Note-taking (lectures, seminars, meetings, etc.)

This scale concerns the ability to grasp key information and write coherent notes, which is valuable in academic and professional life. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ type of source text: from demonstrations and instructions, through straightforward lectures and meetings on subjects in their field, to meetings and seminars on unfamiliar, complex subjects;
- ▶ consideration on the part of the speaker/signer (lower levels): from a slow and clear delivery, plus pauses to take notes, through clearly articulated, well-structured lectures, to multiple sources;
- ▶ type of note-taking: from taking notes as a series of points (lower levels), through notes on what seems to them to be important, to appropriate selection of what to note and what to omit;
- ▶ accuracy of the notes (higher levels): from notes precise enough for own use (B1), through accurate notes on meetings in their field (B2), to accurate capture of abstract concepts, relationships between ideas, implications and allusions.

	Note-taking (lectures, seminars, meetings, etc.)
C2	Can, while continuing to participate in a meeting or seminar, create reliable notes (or minutes) for people who are not present, even when the subject matter is complex and/or unfamiliar. Is aware of the implications and allusions of what is said and can take notes on them as well as on the actual words used. Can take notes selectively, paraphrasing and abbreviating successfully to capture abstract concepts and relationships between ideas.
C1	Can take detailed notes during a lecture on topics in their field of interest, recording the information so accurately and so closely to the original that the notes could also be useful to other people. Can make decisions about what to note down and what to omit as the lecture or seminar proceeds, even on unfamiliar matters. Can select relevant, detailed information and arguments on complex, abstract topics from multiple oral sources (e.g. lectures, podcasts, formal discussions and debates, interviews), provided the delivery is at normal speed.
B2	Can understand a clearly structured lecture on a familiar subject, and can take notes on points which strike them as important, even though they tend to concentrate on the actual formulation and therefore to miss some information. Can take accurate notes in meetings and seminars on most matters likely to arise within their field of interest.
B1	Can take notes during a lecture which are precise enough for their own use at a later date, provided the topic is within their field of interest and the lecture is clear and well structured. Can take notes as a list of key points during a straightforward lecture, provided the topic is familiar, and the lecture is both formulated in simple language and articulated clearly. Can note down routine instructions in a meeting on a familiar subject, provided these are formulated in simple language and they are given sufficient time to do so.
A2	Can take simple notes at a presentation/demonstration where the subject matter is familiar and predictable and the presenter allows for clarification and note-taking.
A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>
Pre-A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>

Creative texts

Creative texts are one of the main sources for “Reading as a leisure activity” and there are several descriptors related to the reading of literature in the scale with that title. However, creative texts are not confined to literature or indeed to script. Film, theatre, recitals and multimodal installations are just some of the other types of creative text, as works of imagination and cultural significance. Therefore, while some of the descriptors in this section do refer explicitly to scripted text and/or literature, many refer to “the work” concerned.

Creative texts tend to evoke a reaction, and this is often promoted in language education. This response may be expressed in a classroom or in one of the amateur literacy circles often associated with foreign language learning.

There are perhaps four main types of classic response:

- ▶ engagement: giving a personal reaction to the language, style or content, feeling drawn to an aspect of the work or a character or characteristic of it;
- ▶ interpretation: ascribing meaning or significance to aspects of the work including content, motifs, character motives, metaphor, etc.
- ▶ analysis of certain aspects of the work including language, literary devices, context, characters, relationships, etc.
- ▶ evaluation: giving a critical appraisal of technique, structure, the vision of the artist, the significance of the work, etc.

There is a fundamental difference between the first two categories (engagement and interpretation) and the last two (analysis and evaluation). Describing a personal reaction and interpretation is cognitively far simpler than giving a more intellectual analysis and/or evaluation. Therefore, two different scales are offered.

Expressing a personal response to creative texts (including literature)

This first scale reflects the approach taken in school sectors and in adult reading circles. It focuses on expression of the effect that a work has on the user/learner as an individual. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ explaining what they liked, what interested them about the work;
- ▶ describing characters, saying which they identified with;
- ▶ relating aspects of the work to their own experience;
- ▶ relating feelings and emotions;
- ▶ personal interpretation of the work as a whole or of aspects of it.

Progression up the scale is characterised as follows: at the lower levels the user/learner can say whether they liked the work, say how it made them feel, discuss characters and relate aspects of the work to their own experience, with increased detail at B1. At B2 they can give more elaborate explanations, comment on the form of expression and style and give their interpretation of the development of a plot, the characters and the themes in a story, novel, film or play. At the C levels, they can give broader and deeper interpretations, supporting them with details and examples.

	Expressing a personal response to creative texts (including literature)
C2	<i>No descriptors available</i>
C1	Can describe in detail a personal interpretation of a work, outlining their reactions to certain features and explaining their significance. Can outline a personal interpretation of a character in a work: their psychological/emotional state, the motives for their actions and the consequences of these actions.
B2	Can give a clear presentation of their reactions to a work, developing their ideas and supporting them with examples and arguments. Can give a personal interpretation of the development of a plot, the characters and themes in a story, novel, film or play. Can describe their emotional response to a work and elaborate on the way in which it has evoked this response. Can express in some detail their reactions to the form of expression, style and content of a work, explaining what they appreciated and why.

	Expressing a personal response to creative texts (including literature)
B1	Can explain why certain parts or aspects of a work especially interested them. Can explain in some detail which character they most identified with and why. Can relate events in a story, film or play to similar events they have experienced or heard about. Can relate the emotions experienced by a character to emotions they have experienced. Can describe the emotions they experienced at a certain point in a story, e.g. the point(s) in a story when they became anxious for a character, and explain why. Can explain briefly the feelings and opinions that a work provoked in them. Can describe the personality of a character. Can describe a character's feelings and explain the reasons for them.
A2	Can express their reactions to a work, reporting their feelings and ideas in simple language. Can state in simple language which aspects of a work especially interested them. Can state whether they liked a work or not and explain why in simple language.
A1	Can use simple words/signs to state how a work made them feel.
Pre-A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>

Analysis and criticism of creative texts (including literature)

This scale represents an approach more common at an upper secondary and university level. It concerns more formal, intellectual reactions. Aspects analysed include the significance of events in a novel, the treatment of the same themes in different works and other links between them, the extent to which a work follows conventions, and more global evaluation of the work as a whole. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include:

- ▶ comparing different works;
- ▶ giving a reasoned opinion of a work;
- ▶ critically evaluating features of a work, including the effectiveness of its techniques.

Progression up the scale is characterised as follows: there are no descriptors for A1 and A2. Until B2, the focus is on description rather than evaluation. At B2, the user/learner can analyse similarities and differences between works, giving a reasoned opinion and referring to the views of others. At C1, analysis becomes more subtle, concerned with the way the work engages the audience, the extent to which it is conventional, or whether it employs irony. At C2, the user/learner can recognise finer linguistic and stylistic subtleties, unpack connotations and give more critical appraisals of the way in which structure, language and rhetorical devices are exploited in a work of literature for a particular purpose.

	Analysis and criticism of creative texts (including literature)
C2	Can give a critical appraisal of work of different periods and genres (e.g. novels, poems and plays), appreciating subtle distinctions of style and implicit as well as explicit meaning. Can recognise the finer subtleties of nuanced language, rhetorical effect and stylistic language use (e.g. metaphors, abnormal syntax, ambiguity), interpreting and "unpacking" meanings and connotations. Can critically evaluate the way in which structure, language and rhetorical devices are exploited in a work for a particular purpose and give a reasoned argument concerning their appropriateness and effectiveness. Can give a critical appreciation of deliberate breaches of linguistic conventions in a piece of writing.
C1	Can critically appraise a wide variety of texts including literary works of different periods and genres. Can evaluate the extent to which a work follows the conventions of its genre. Can describe and comment on ways in which the work engages the audience (e.g. by building up and subverting expectations).

	Analysis and criticism of creative texts (including literature)
B2	Can compare two works, considering themes, characters and scenes, exploring similarities and contrasts and explaining the relevance of the connections between them. Can give a reasoned opinion of a work, showing awareness of the thematic, structural and formal features and referring to the opinions and arguments of others. Can evaluate the way the work encourages identification with characters, giving examples. Can describe the way in which different works differ in their treatment of the same theme.
B1	Can point out the most important episodes and events in a clearly structured narrative in everyday language and explain the significance of events and the connections between them. Can describe the key themes and characters in short narratives involving familiar situations that contain only high frequency everyday language.
A2	Can identify and briefly describe, in basic formulaic language, the key themes and characters in short, simple narratives involving familiar situations that contain only high frequency everyday language.
A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>
Pre-A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>

3.4.1.2. Mediating concepts

It is recognised in education that language is a tool used to think about a subject and to articulate that thinking in a dynamic co-constructive process. A key component of the development of mediation scales, therefore, is to capture this function. How can the user/learner facilitate access to knowledge and concepts through language? There are two main ways in which this occurs: one is in the context of collaborative work and the other is when someone has the official or unofficial role of facilitator, teacher or trainer. In either context, it is virtually impossible to develop concepts without preparing the ground for it by managing the relational issues concerned. For this reason, two scales are presented for collaborating in a group, and for leading group work. In each case the first scale, presented on the left in the table, concerns establishing the conditions for effective work (= relational mediation).

The second scale, presented on the right in the table, is concerned with the development and elaboration of ideas (= cognitive mediation). As is the case with different aspects of communicative language competence, or of plurilingual and pluricultural competence, distinctions are made to assist reflection, but real communication requires a holistic integration of different aspects. The four descriptor scales in this section thus form pairs, as indicated below.

	Establishing conditions	Developing ideas
Collaborating in a group	Facilitating collaborative interaction with peers	Collaborating to construct meaning
Leading group work	Managing interaction	Encouraging conceptual talk

The two scales under “establishing conditions” focus on building and maintaining positive interactions and do not deal directly with access to new knowledge and concepts. However, such mediation may well be a necessary precursor or indeed parallel activity in order to facilitate the development of new knowledge. People must be sensitive to others’ views, so a positive atmosphere is often a prerequisite for collaborative engagement that may lead to new knowledge. Although these four scales are directly relevant to the educational domain, they are not confined to the classroom because they are applicable to all domains where there is a need to move people’s thinking forward.

Facilitating collaborative interaction with peers

The user/learner contributes to successful collaboration in a group that they belong to, usually with a specific shared objective or communicative task in mind. They are concerned with making conscious interventions where appropriate to orient the discussion, balance contributions and help to overcome communication difficulties within the group. They do not have a designated lead role in the group, and are not concerned with creating a lead role for themselves, being concerned solely with successful collaboration. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ collaborative participation by consciously managing one's own role and contributions to group communication;
- ▶ active orientation of teamwork by helping to review key points and consider or define next steps;
- ▶ use of questions and contributions to move the discussion forward in a productive way;
- ▶ use of questions and turntaking to balance contributions from other group members with their own contributions.

Progression up the scale is characterised as follows: at A2, the user/learner can collaborate actively in simple, shared tasks, provided someone helps them express their suggestions. At B1, the focus is on posing questions and inviting others to contribute. By B2, the learner/user can refocus the discussion, helping to define goals and comparing ways of achieving them. At C1, they can help steer a discussion tactfully towards a conclusion.

Collaborating to construct meaning

This scale is concerned with stimulating and developing ideas as a member of a group. It is particularly relevant to collaborative work in problem solving, brainstorming, concept development and project work.

Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ cognitively framing collaborative tasks by deciding on aims, processes and steps;
- ▶ co-constructing ideas/solutions;
- ▶ asking others to explain their thinking and identifying inconsistencies in their thought processes;
- ▶ summarising the discussion and deciding on next steps.

Progression up the scale is characterised as follows: the scale moves from simple questioning techniques and the organisation of tasks at B1 to further developing other people's ideas and opinions, co-developing ideas (B2/B2+) to evaluating problems, challenges and proposals, highlighting inconsistencies in thinking (C1), and guiding discussion effectively to a consensus at C2.

Collaborating in a group		
	Facilitating collaborative interaction with peers	Collaborating to construct meaning
C2	<i>No descriptors available</i>	Can summarise, evaluate and link the various contributions in order to facilitate agreement on a solution or a way forward.
C1	Can show sensitivity to different perspectives within a group, acknowledging contributions and formulating any reservations, disagreements or criticisms in such a way as to avoid or minimise any offence. Can develop the interaction and tactfully help steer it towards a conclusion.	Can frame a discussion to decide on a course of action with a partner or group, reporting on what others have said, summarising, elaborating and weighing up multiple points of view. Can evaluate problems, challenges and proposals in a collaborative discussion in order to decide on the way forward. Can highlight inconsistencies in thinking, and challenge others' ideas in the process of trying to reach a consensus.
B2	Can, based on people's reactions, adjust the way they formulate questions and/or intervene in a group interaction. Can act as rapporteur in a group discussion, noting ideas and decisions, discussing these with the group and later giving a summary of the group's view(s) in a plenary.	Can highlight the main issue that needs to be resolved in a complex task and the important aspects that need to be taken into account. Can contribute to collaborative decision making and problem solving, expressing and co-developing ideas, explaining details and making suggestions for future action. Can help organise the discussion in a group by reporting what others have said, summarising, elaborating and weighing up different points of view.
	Can ask questions to stimulate discussion on how to organise collaborative work. Can help define goals for teamwork and compare options for how to achieve them. Can refocus a discussion by suggesting what to consider next, and how to proceed.	Can further develop other people's ideas and opinions. Can present their ideas in a group and pose questions that invite reactions from other group members' perspectives. Can consider two different sides of an issue, giving arguments for and against, and propose a solution or compromise.

Collaborating in a group		
	Facilitating collaborative interaction with peers	Collaborating to construct meaning
B1	Can collaborate on a shared task, e.g. formulating and responding to suggestions, asking whether people agree, and proposing alternative approaches. Can collaborate in simple, shared tasks and work towards a common goal in a group by asking and answering straightforward questions. Can define the task in basic terms in a discussion and ask others to contribute their expertise and experience. Can invite other people in a group to contribute their views.	Can organise the work in a straightforward collaborative task by stating the aim and explaining in a simple manner the main issue that needs to be resolved. Can use questions, comments and simple reformulations to maintain the focus of a discussion. Can ask a group member to give the reason(s) for their views. Can repeat part of what someone has said to confirm mutual understanding and help keep the development of ideas on course. Can ensure that the person they are addressing understands what they mean by asking appropriate questions. Can make simple remarks and pose occasional questions to indicate that they are following. Can make suggestions in a simple way. Can express an idea and ask what others think, using very simple words/signs and phrases, provided they can prepare in advance.
A2	Can collaborate in simple, shared tasks, provided other participants articulate slowly and one or more people help them contribute and express their suggestions. Can collaborate in simple, practical tasks, asking what others think, making suggestions and understanding responses, provided they can ask for repetition or reformulation from time to time. Can invite others' contributions to very simple tasks using short, simple phrases prepared in advance. Can indicate that they understand and ask whether others understand.	No descriptors available
A1		
Pre-A1	No descriptors available	No descriptors available

Managing interaction

This scale is intended for situations in which the user/learner has a designated lead role to organise communicative activity between members of a group or several groups, for example as a teacher, workshop facilitator, trainer or meeting chair. They have a conscious approach to managing phases of communication that may include both plenary communication with the whole group, and/or management of communication within and between sub-groups. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ leading plenary activity;
- ▶ giving instructions and checking understanding of communicative task objectives;
- ▶ monitoring and facilitating communication within the group or sub-groups without impeding the flow of communication between group participants;
- ▶ reorienting communication in the group or sub-groups; intervening to put a group back on task;
- ▶ adapting one's own contributions and interactive role to support group communication, according to need.

Progression up the scale is characterised as follows: at B1 the user/learner can give clear instructions, allocate turns, and bring participants in a group back to the task. These aspects are extended at B2 with explanations of different roles, ground rules and an ability to put a group back on task with new instructions or to encourage more balanced participation. Several descriptors on monitoring clustered at B2+; only one of these has been kept in the scale. By C1, the user/learner can organise a varied and balanced sequence of plenary, group and individual work, ensuring smooth transitions between the phases, intervening diplomatically in order to redirect discussion, to prevent one person dominating or to confront disruptive behaviour. At C2, they can take on different roles as appropriate, recognise undercurrents and give appropriate guidance, and provide individualised support.

Encouraging conceptual talk

Encouraging conceptual talk involves providing scaffolding to enable another person or persons to themselves construct a new concept, rather than passively following a lead. The user/learner may do this as a member of a group, taking temporarily the role of facilitator, or they may have the designated role of an expert (for example, an animator, teacher, trainer or manager) who is leading the group in order to help them understand concepts. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ asking questions to stimulate logical reasoning (dialogic talk);
- ▶ building contributions into logical, coherent discourse.

Progression up the scale is characterised as follows: the scale moves from showing interest at A1, through asking simple questions to bring someone into a discussion or to ask someone's opinion at A2, to monitoring discussion and posing higher order questions at B2+ and above, in order to encourage logical reasoning, justification of ideas and the construction of coherent lines of thinking.

Leading group work		
	Managing interaction	Encouraging conceptual talk
C2	Can take on different roles according to the needs of the participants and requirements of the activity (resource person, mediator, supervisor, etc.) and provide appropriate individualised support. Can recognise undercurrents in interaction and take appropriate steps to guide the direction of discussion.	Can effectively lead the development of ideas in a discussion of complex abstract topics, giving direction by targeting questions and encouraging others to elaborate on their reasoning.
C1	Can organise a varied and balanced sequence of plenary, group and individual work, ensuring smooth transitions between the phases. Can intervene diplomatically in order to redirect discussion, prevent one person dominating or confront disruptive behaviour.	Can ask a series of open questions that build on different contributions in order to stimulate logical reasoning (e.g. hypothesising, inferring, analysing, justifying and predicting).
B2	Can organise and manage collaborative group work efficiently. Can monitor individual and group work non-intrusively, intervening to set a group back on task or to ensure even participation. Can intervene supportively in order to focus people's attention on aspects of the task by asking targeted questions and inviting suggestions.	Can encourage members of a group to describe and elaborate on their thinking. Can encourage members of a group to build on one another's information and ideas to come up with a concept or solution.
	Can explain the different roles of participants in the collaborative process, giving clear instructions for group work. Can explain ground rules of collaborative discussion in small groups that involves problem solving or the evaluation of alternative proposals. Can intervene when necessary to set a group back on task with new instructions or to encourage more even participation.	Can formulate questions and feedback to encourage people to expand on their thinking and justify or clarify their opinions. Can build on people's ideas and link them into coherent lines of thinking. Can ask people to explain how an idea fits with the main topic under discussion.
B1	Can allocate turns in a discussion, inviting a participant to express their views.	Can ask people to elaborate on specific points they made in their initial explanation. Can ask appropriate questions to check understanding of concepts that have been explained. Can ask questions to invite people to clarify their reasoning.
	Can give simple, clear instructions to organise an activity.	Can ask why someone thinks something, or how they think something would work.
A2	Can give very simple instructions to a co-operative group, given some help with formulation when necessary.	Can ask what somebody thinks of a certain idea.
A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>	Can use simple isolated words/signs and non-verbal signals to show interest in an idea.
Pre-A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>	<i>No descriptors available</i>

3.4.1.3. Mediating communication

Despite the brevity of the presentation of mediation in the 2001 CEFR text, the social aspect is underlined. Mediation concerns a language user who plays the role of intermediary between different interlocutors, engaged in activities that “occupy an important place in the normal linguistic functioning of our societies” (CEFR Section 2.1.3). Language is of course not the only reason why people sometimes have difficulty understanding one another. Even if one thinks of mediation in terms of rendering a text comprehensible, the difficulty in comprehension may well be due to a lack of familiarity with the area or field concerned. Understanding the other requires an effort of translation from one’s own perspective to the other, keeping both perspectives in mind; sometimes people need a third person or a third space in order to achieve this. Sometimes there are delicate situations, tensions or even disagreements that need to be faced in order to create the conditions for any understanding and hence any communication.

The descriptors for mediating communication will therefore have direct relevance to teachers, trainers, students and professionals who wish to develop their awareness and competence in this area, in order to achieve better outcomes in their communicative encounters in a particular language or languages, particularly when there is an intercultural element involved.

Facilitating pluricultural space

This scale reflects the notion of creating a shared space between linguistically and culturally different interlocutors (that is, the capacity to deal with “otherness”, to identify similarities and differences, to build on known and unknown cultural features, and so on) in order to enable communication and collaboration. The user/learner aims to facilitate a positive interactive environment for successful communication between participants of different cultural backgrounds, including in multicultural contexts. Rather than simply building on their pluricultural repertoire to gain acceptance and to enhance their own mission or message (see “Building on pluricultural repertoire”), they are engaged as a cultural mediator: creating a neutral, trusted, shared “space” in order to enhance communication between others. They aim to expand and deepen intercultural understanding between participants in order to avoid and/or overcome any potential communication difficulties arising from contrasting cultural viewpoints. Naturally, the mediator themselves needs a continually developing awareness of sociocultural and sociolinguistic differences affecting cross-cultural communication. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ using questions and showing interest to promote understanding of cultural norms and perspectives between participants;
- ▶ demonstrating sensitivity to and respect for different sociocultural and sociolinguistic perspectives and norms;
- ▶ anticipating, dealing with and/or repairing misunderstandings arising from sociocultural and sociolinguistic differences.

Progression up the scale is characterised as follows: at B1 the emphasis is on introducing people and showing interest and empathy by asking and answering questions. By B2+, appreciation of different perspectives and flexibility are central: the ability to belong to a group yet maintain balance and distance, express oneself sensitively, clarify misunderstandings and explain how things were meant. This aspect is developed further in the C levels, where the user/learner can control their actions and expression according to context, making subtle adjustments in order to prevent and/or repair misunderstandings and cultural incidents. By C2, they can mediate effectively and naturally, taking account of sociocultural and sociolinguistic differences.

	Facilitating pluricultural space
C2	Can mediate effectively and naturally between members of their own and other communities, taking account of sociocultural and sociolinguistic differences. Can guide a sensitive discussion effectively, identifying nuances and undercurrents.
C1	Can act as a mediator in intercultural encounters, contributing to a shared communication culture by managing ambiguity, offering advice and support, and heading off misunderstandings. Can anticipate how people might misunderstand what has been said or written and can help maintain positive interaction by commenting on and interpreting different cultural perspectives on the issue concerned.

	Facilitating pluricultural space
B2	Can exploit knowledge of sociocultural conventions in order to establish a consensus on how to proceed in a particular situation that is unfamiliar to everyone involved. Can, in intercultural encounters, demonstrate appreciation of perspectives other than that of their own worldview, and express themselves in a way appropriate to the context. Can clarify misunderstandings and misinterpretations during intercultural encounters, suggesting how things were actually meant in order to clear the air and move the discussion forward.
B1	Can encourage a shared communication culture by expressing understanding and appreciation of different ideas, feelings and viewpoints, and inviting participants to contribute and react to each other's ideas. Can work collaboratively with people who have different cultural orientations, discussing similarities and differences in views and perspectives. Can, when collaborating with people from other cultures, adapt the way they work in order to create shared procedures.
A2	Can support communication across cultures by initiating conversation, showing interest and empathy by asking and answering simple questions, and expressing agreement and understanding. Can act in a supportive manner in intercultural encounters, recognising the feelings and different worldviews of other members of the group.
A1	Can support an intercultural exchange using a limited repertoire to introduce people from different cultural backgrounds and to ask and answer questions, showing awareness that some questions may be perceived differently in the cultures concerned. Can help develop a shared communication culture, by exchanging information in a simple way about values and attitudes to language and culture.
Pre-A1	No descriptors available

Acting as an intermediary in informal situations (with friends and colleagues)

This scale is intended for situations in which the user/learner as a plurilingual individual mediates across languages and cultures to the best of their ability in an informal situation in the public, private, occupational or educational domain. The scale is therefore not concerned with the activities of professional interpreters. The mediation may be in one direction (for example, during a welcome speech) or in two directions (for example, during a conversation). Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ informally communicating the sense of what speakers/signers are saying in a conversation;
- ▶ conveying important information (for example, in a situation at work);
- ▶ repeating the sense of what is expressed in speeches and presentations.

Progression up the scale is characterised as follows: at the A levels, the user/learner can assist in a very simple manner, but by A2+ and B1 they can mediate in predictable everyday situations. However, such assistance is dependent on the interlocutors being supportive in that they alter their expression or will repeat information as necessary. At B2, the user/learner can mediate competently within their fields of interest, given the pauses to do so, and by C1 they can do this fluently on a wide range of subjects. At C2 the user/learner can also convey the meaning of the interlocutors faithfully, reflecting the style, register and cultural context.

	Acting as an intermediary in informal situations (with friends and colleagues)
C2	Can communicate in a clear, fluent, well-structured way (in Language B) the sense of what is said (in Language A) on a wide range of general and specialised topics, maintaining appropriate style and register, conveying finer shades of meaning and elaborating on sociocultural implications.
C1	Can communicate fluently (in Language B) the sense of what is said (in Language A) on a wide range of subjects of personal, academic and professional interest, conveying significant information clearly and concisely as well as explaining cultural references.
B2	Can mediate (between Language A and Language B) conveying detailed information, drawing the attention of both sides to background information and sociocultural cues, and posing clarification and follow-up questions or statements as necessary.
	Can communicate (in Language B) the sense of what is said in a welcome address, anecdote or presentation in their field (given in Language A), interpreting cultural cues appropriately and giving additional explanations when necessary, provided the presenter stops frequently in order to allow time for them to do so. Can communicate (in Language B) the sense of what is said (in Language A) on subjects within their fields of interest, conveying and when necessary explaining the significance of important statements and viewpoints, provided the interlocutors give clarifications if needed.
B1	Can communicate (in Language B) the main sense of what is said (in Language A) on subjects within their fields of interest, conveying straightforward factual information and explicit cultural references, provided they can prepare beforehand and that the interlocutors articulate clearly in everyday language.
	Can communicate (in Language B) the main sense of what is said (in Language A) on subjects of personal interest, while following important politeness conventions, provided the interlocutors articulate clearly and they can ask for clarification and pause to plan how to express things.
A2	Can communicate (in Language B) the overall sense of what is said (in Language A) in everyday situations, following basic cultural conventions and conveying the essential information, provided this is articulated clearly and they can ask for repetition and clarification.
	Can communicate (in Language B) the main point of what is said (in Language A) in predictable everyday situations, conveying back and forth information about personal wants and needs, provided other people help with formulation.
A1	Can communicate (in Language B) other people's personal details and very simple, predictable information (in Language A), provided other people help with formulation.
Pre-A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>

Facilitating communication in delicate situations and disagreements

This scale is intended for situations in which the user/learner may have a formal role to mediate in a disagreement between third parties, or may informally try to resolve a misunderstanding, delicate situation or disagreement between them. The user/learner is primarily concerned with clarifying what the problem is and what the parties want, helping them understand each other's positions. They may well attempt to persuade the third parties to move closer to a resolution of the issue. They are not at all concerned with their own viewpoint, but seek balance in the representation of the viewpoints of the other parties involved in the discussion. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ exploring in a sensitive and balanced way the different viewpoints represented by participants in the dialogue;
- ▶ elaborating on viewpoints expressed to enhance and deepen participants' understanding of the issues discussed;
- ▶ establishing common ground;
- ▶ establishing possible areas of concession between participants;
- ▶ mediating a shift in viewpoint of one or more participants, to move closer to an agreement or resolution.

Progression up the scale is characterised as follows: at the A levels, the user/learner can recognise when disagreements occur. At B1, they can obtain explanations, demonstrate understanding of the issues and seek clarifications where necessary. At B2, they can outline the main issues and the positions of the parties concerned, identify common ground, highlight possible solutions and summarise what is agreed on. These skills are deepened at B2+, with the user/learner showing detailed awareness of the issues and eliciting possible solutions. At the C levels, they have the diplomatic and persuasive language to do this more effectively, guiding a delicate discussion sensitively.

	Facilitating communication in delicate situations and disagreements
C2	Can deal tactfully with a disruptive participant, framing any remarks diplomatically in relation to the situation and cultural perceptions. Can confidently take a firm but diplomatic stance over an issue of principle, while showing respect for the viewpoints of others.
C1	Can demonstrate sensitivity to different viewpoints, using repetition and paraphrase to demonstrate a detailed understanding of each party's requirements for an agreement. Can formulate a diplomatic request to each side in a disagreement to determine what is central to their position, and what they may be willing to give up under certain circumstances. Can use persuasive language to suggest that parties in disagreement shift towards a new position.
B2	Can elicit possible solutions from parties in disagreement in order to help them to reach consensus, formulating open-ended, neutral questions to minimise embarrassment or offence. Can help the parties in a disagreement better understand each other by restating and reframing their positions more clearly and by prioritising needs and goals. Can formulate a clear and accurate summary of what has been agreed and what is expected from each of the parties. Can, by asking questions, identify areas of common ground and invite each side to highlight possible solutions. Can outline the main points in a disagreement with reasonable precision and explain the positions of the parties involved. Can summarise the statements made by the two sides, highlighting areas of agreement and obstacles to agreement.
B1	Can ask parties in a disagreement to explain their point of view, and can respond briefly to their explanations, provided the topic is familiar to them and the parties express themselves clearly. Can demonstrate their understanding of the key issues in a disagreement on a topic familiar to them and make simple requests for confirmation and/or clarification.
A2	Can recognise when people disagree or when difficulties occur in interaction and adapt memorised, simple phrases to seek compromise and agreement.
A1	Can recognise when people disagree or when someone has a problem and can use memorised, simple expressions (e.g. "I understand" or "Are you okay?") to indicate sympathy.
Pre-A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>

3.4.2. Mediation strategies

The user/learner's ability to mediate does not only involve being linguistically competent in the relevant language or languages; it also entails using mediation strategies that are appropriate in relation to the conventions, conditions and constraints of the communicative context. Mediation strategies are the techniques employed to clarify meaning and facilitate understanding. As a mediator, the user/learner may need to shuttle between people, between texts, between types of discourse and between languages, varieties or modalities, depending on the mediation context. The strategies here presented are communication strategies, that is, ways of helping people to understand, during the actual process of mediation. They concern the way source content is processed for the

recipient. For instance, is it necessary to elaborate it, to condense it, to paraphrase it, to simplify it, to illustrate it with metaphors or visuals? The strategies are presented separately because they apply to many of the activities.

3.4.2.1. Strategies to explain a new concept

Linking to previous knowledge

Establishing links to previous knowledge is a significant part of the mediation process since it is an essential part of the learning process. The mediator may explain new information by making comparisons, by describing how it relates to something the recipient already knows or by helping recipients activate previous knowledge, for example. Links may be made to other texts, relating new information and concepts to previous material, and to background knowledge of the world. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ posing questions to encourage people to activate prior knowledge;
- ▶ making comparisons and/or links between new and prior knowledge;
- ▶ providing examples and definitions.

Progression up the scale is characterised as follows: there is a progression from comparison to familiar everyday experience at B1, through awareness raising with clear explanations of links at B2, to extended, spontaneous definition of complex concepts that draw on previous knowledge at C2.

Adapting language

The user/learner may need to employ shifts in use of language, style and/or register in order to incorporate the content of a text into a new text of a different genre and register. This may be done through the inclusion of synonyms, similes, simplification or paraphrasing. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ paraphrasing;
- ▶ adapting delivery;
- ▶ explaining technical terminology.

Progression up the scale is characterised as follows: from A2 to B2 the user/learner can exploit paraphrasing and simplification to make the content of texts more accessible. B2 descriptors concern paraphrasing difficult concepts and technical topics comprehensible with paraphrasing, and conscious adaptation of the language used. At the C levels, concepts are technical or complex, and the user/learner is able to present the content in a different genre or register that is appropriate for the audience and purpose.

Breaking down complicated information

Understanding can often be enhanced by breaking down complicated information into constituent parts, and showing how these parts fit together to give the whole picture. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ breaking a process into a series of steps;
- ▶ presenting ideas or instructions as bullet points;
- ▶ presenting separately the main points in a chain of argument.

Progression up the scale is characterised as follows: at B1 the user/learner can present instructions or informational text one point at a time. At B2, they can break down complicated processes or arguments and present their components separately. At C1, there is an added emphasis on reinforcement and recapitulation, and at C2 the user/learner can explain the relationship of parts to the whole and encourage different ways of analysing the issue.

Strategies to explain a new concept			
	Linking to previous knowledge	Adapting language	Breaking down complicated information
C2	Can introduce complex concepts (e.g. scientific notions) by providing extended definitions and explanations that draw on previous knowledge that can be assumed.	Can adapt the language of a very wide range of texts in order to present the main content in a register and degree of sophistication and detail appropriate to the audience concerned.	Can facilitate understanding of a complex issue by explaining the relationship of parts to the whole and encourage different ways of approaching it.
C1	Can spontaneously pose a series of questions to encourage people to think about their prior knowledge of an abstract issue and to help them establish a link to what is going to be explained.	Can explain technical terminology and difficult concepts when communicating with non-experts about matters within their own field of specialisation. Can adapt their language (e.g. syntax, idiomaticity, jargon) in order to make a complex specialist topic accessible to recipients who are not familiar with it. Can paraphrase and interpret complex, technical texts, using suitably non-technical language for a recipient who does not have specialist knowledge.	Can facilitate understanding of a complex issue by highlighting and categorising the main points, and reinforcing the message by repeating the key aspects in different ways.
B2	Can clearly explain the connections between the goals of the session and the personal or professional interests and experiences of the participant(s).	Can explain technical topics within their field, using suitably non-technical language for a recipient who does not have specialist knowledge. Can make a specific, complex piece of information in their field clearer and more explicit for others by paraphrasing it in simpler language.	Can make a complicated issue easier to understand by presenting the components of the argument separately.
	Can formulate questions and give feedback to encourage people to make connections to previous knowledge and experiences. Can explain a new concept or procedure by comparing and contrasting it to one that people are already familiar with.	Can make accessible for others the main contents of a text on a subject of interest (e.g. an essay, a forum discussion, a presentation) by paraphrasing in simpler language.	Can make a complicated process easier to understand by breaking it down into a series of smaller steps.

Strategies to explain a new concept			
	Linking to previous knowledge	Adapting language	Breaking down complicated information
B1	Can explain how something works by providing examples that draw on people's everyday experiences.	Can paraphrase more simply the main points made in short, straightforward texts on familiar subjects (e.g. short magazine articles, interviews) to make the contents accessible for others.	Can make a short instructional or informational text easier to understand by presenting it as a list of separate points.
	Can show how new information is related to what people are familiar with by asking simple questions.	Can paraphrase short passages in a simple fashion, using the original order of the text.	Can make a set of instructions easier to understand by repeating them slowly, a few words/signs at a time, employing verbal and non-verbal emphasis to facilitate understanding.
A2	<i>No descriptors available</i>	Can repeat the main point of a simple message on an everyday subject, using different formulation to help someone else understand it.	<i>No descriptors available</i>
A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>	<i>No descriptors available</i>	<i>No descriptors available</i>
Pre-A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>	<i>No descriptors available</i>	<i>No descriptors available</i>

3.4.2.2. Strategies to simplify a text

Amplifying a dense text

Density of information is often an obstacle to understanding. This scale is concerned with the expansion of the input source through the inclusion of helpful information, examples, details, background information, reasoning and explanatory comments. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ using repetition and redundancy, for example by paraphrasing in different ways;
- ▶ modifying style to explain things more explicitly;
- ▶ giving examples.

Progression up the scale is characterised as follows: at B1 and B2 the emphasis is on providing repetition and further examples, whereas at the C levels the focus is more on elaboration and explanation, adding helpful detail.

Streamlining a text

This scale is concerned with the opposite to “Amplifying” in the scale above, namely pruning a written text to its essential message(s). This may involve expressing the same information more economically by eliminating repetition and digressions, and excluding those sections of the source that do not add relevant new information. However, it may also involve regrouping the source ideas in order to highlight important points, to draw conclusions or to compare and contrast them. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ highlighting key information;
- ▶ eliminating repetition and digressions;
- ▶ excluding what is not relevant for the audience.

Progression up the scale is characterised as follows: highlighting may be simply underlining or inserting marks in the margin at A2+/B1 but becomes a complete rewrite of the source text at C2. At B2, the learner is able to edit the source text to remove irrelevance and repetition. At the C levels, the focus switches to tailoring a source text for a particular audience.

Strategies to simplify a text		
	Amplifying a dense text	Streamlining a text
C2	Can elucidate the information given in texts on complex academic or professional topics by elaborating and providing examples.	Can redraft a complex source text, improving coherence, cohesion and the flow of an argument, while removing sections unnecessary for its purpose.
C1	Can make complex, challenging content more accessible by explaining difficult aspects more explicitly and adding helpful detail. Can make the main points contained in a complex text more accessible to the target audience by adding redundancy, explaining, and modifying style and register.	Can reorganise a complex source text in order to focus on the points of most relevance to the target audience.
B2	Can make the content of a text on a subject in their fields of interest more accessible to a target audience by adding examples, reasoning and explanatory comments.	Can simplify a source text by excluding non-relevant or repetitive information and taking into consideration the intended audience.
	Can make concepts on subjects in their fields of interest more accessible by giving concrete examples, recapitulating step by step and repeating the main points. Can make new information more accessible by using repetition and adding illustrations.	Can edit a source text by deleting the parts that do not add new information that is relevant for a given audience in order to make the significant content more accessible for them. Can identify related or repeated information in different parts of a text and merge it in order to make the essential message clearer.
B1	Can make an aspect of an everyday topic clearer and more explicit by conveying the main information in another way.	Can identify and mark (e.g. underline, highlight) the essential information in a straightforward, informational text, in order to pass this information on to someone else.
	Can make an aspect of an everyday topic clearer by providing simple examples.	
A2	<i>No descriptors available</i>	Can identify and mark (e.g. underline, highlight) the key sentences in a short everyday text.
A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>	<i>No descriptors available</i>
Pre-A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>	<i>No descriptors available</i>

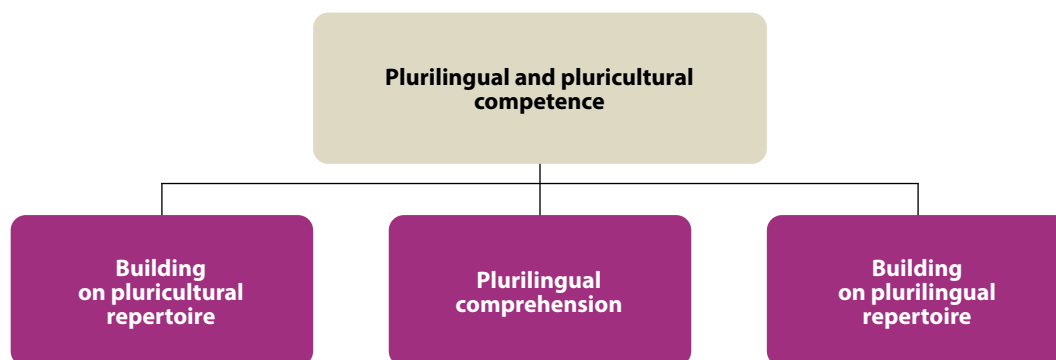
Chapter 4

THE CEFR ILLUSTRATIVE DESCRIPTOR SCALES: PLURILINGUAL AND PLURICULTURAL COMPETENCE

The notions of plurilingualism and pluriculturalism presented in the CEFR 2001 (Sections 1.3, 1.4, and 6.1.3) were the starting point for the development of descriptors in this area. The plurilingual vision associated with the CEFR gives value to cultural and linguistic diversity at the level of the individual. It promotes the need for learners as “social agents” to draw on all their linguistic and cultural resources and experiences in order to fully participate in social and educational contexts, achieving mutual understanding, gaining access to knowledge and in turn, further developing their linguistic and cultural repertoire. As the CEFR 2001 states:

the plurilingual approach emphasises the fact that as an individual person’s experience of language in its cultural contexts expands, from the language of the home to that of society at large and then to the languages of other peoples (whether learnt at school or college, or by direct experience), he or she does not keep these languages and cultures in strictly separated mental compartments, but rather builds up a communicative competence to which all knowledge and experience of language contributes and in which languages interrelate and interact. (CEFR 2001 Section 1.3)

Figure 15 – Plurilingual and pluricultural competence



The vision of the learner as a social agent in the action-oriented approach takes these concepts further in relation to language education, considering that:

the aim of language education is profoundly modified. It is no longer seen as simply to achieve “mastery” of one or two, or even three languages, each taken in isolation, with the “ideal native speaker” as the ultimate model. Instead, the aim is to develop a linguistic repertory, in which all linguistic abilities have a place. (CEFR 2001 Section 1.3)

In the development of descriptors, the following points mentioned specifically in the CEFR 2001 were given particular attention:

- ▶ languages are interrelated and interconnected, especially at the level of the individual;
- ▶ languages and cultures are not kept in separated mental compartments;
- ▶ all knowledge and experience of languages contribute to building up communicative competence;
- ▶ balanced mastery of different languages is not the goal, but rather the ability (and willingness) to modulate their usage according to the social and communicative situation;
- ▶ barriers between languages can be overcome in communication, and different languages can be used purposefully for conveying messages in the same situation.

Other concepts were also taken into consideration after analysing recent literature:

- ▶ capacity to deal with “otherness” to identify similarities and differences, to build on known and unknown cultural features, etc. in order to enable communication and collaboration;
- ▶ willingness to act as an intercultural mediator;
- ▶ proactive capacity to use knowledge of familiar languages to understand new languages, looking for cognates and internationalisms in order to make sense of texts in unknown languages – while being aware of the danger of “false friends”;
- ▶ capacity to respond in a sociolinguistically appropriate way by incorporating elements of other languages and/or variations of languages in their own discourse for communication purposes;
- ▶ capacity to exploit one’s linguistic repertoire by purposefully blending, embedding and alternating languages at the levels of utterance and discourse;
- ▶ readiness and capacity to expand linguistic/plurilingual and cultural/pluricultural awareness through an attitude of openness and curiosity.

The reason for associating descriptors in this area with CEFR levels is to provide support to curriculum developers and teachers in their efforts (a) to broaden the perspective of language education in their context and (b) to acknowledge and value the linguistic and cultural diversity of their learners. The provision of descriptors in levels is intended to facilitate the selection of relevant plurilingual/pluricultural aims, which are also realistic in relation to the language level of the user/learners concerned.

The scale “Facilitating pluricultural space” is included in the section “Mediating communication”, rather than here, because it focuses on a more proactive role as an intercultural mediator. The three scales in this section describe aspects of the broader conceptual area concerning plurilingual and intercultural education.

This area is the subject of the framework of reference for pluralistic approaches to languages and cultures (FREPA/CARAP), which lists different aspects of plurilingual and intercultural competences in a hypertextual structure independent of language level, organised according to three broad areas: knowledge (*savoir*), attitudes (*savoir-être*) and skills (*savoir-faire*). Users may wish to consult FREPA/CARAP for further reflection and for access to related training materials in this area.

Building on pluricultural repertoire

Many notions that appear in the literature and descriptors for intercultural competence are included, for example:

- ▶ the need to deal with ambiguity when faced with cultural diversity, adjusting reactions, modifying language, etc.
- ▶ the need for understanding that different cultures may have different practices and norms, and that actions may be perceived differently by people belonging to other cultures;
- ▶ the need to take into consideration differences in behaviours (including gestures, tones and attitudes), discussing over-generalisations and stereotypes;
- ▶ the need to recognise similarities and use them as a basis to improve communication;
- ▶ willingness to show sensitivity to differences;
- ▶ readiness to offer and ask for clarification, anticipating possible risks of misunderstanding.

Key concepts operationalised in the scale at most levels include the following:

- ▶ recognising and acting on cultural, socio-pragmatic and sociolinguistic conventions/cues;
- ▶ recognising and interpreting similarities and differences in perspectives, practices and events;
- ▶ evaluating neutrally and critically.

Progression up the scale is characterised as follows: at the A levels the user/learner is capable of recognising potential causes of culturally based complications in communication and of acting appropriately in simple everyday exchanges. At B1 they can generally respond to the most commonly used cultural cues, act according to socio-pragmatic conventions and explain or discuss features of their own and other cultures. At B2, the user/learner can engage effectively in communication, coping with most difficulties that occur, and is usually able to recognise and repair misunderstandings. At the C levels, this develops into an ability to explain sensitively the background to cultural beliefs, values and practices, interpret and discuss aspects of them, cope with sociolinguistic and pragmatic ambiguity and express reactions constructively with cultural appropriateness.

	Building on pluricultural repertoire
C2	Can initiate and control their actions and forms of expression according to context, showing awareness of cultural differences and making subtle adjustments in order to prevent and/or repair misunderstandings and cultural incidents.
C1	Can identify differences in sociolinguistic/-pragmatic conventions, critically reflect on them and adjust their communication accordingly. Can sensitively explain the background to and interpret and discuss aspects of cultural values and practices drawing on intercultural encounters, reading, film, etc. Can deal with ambiguity in cross-cultural communication and express their reactions constructively and culturally appropriately in order to bring clarity.
B2	**Can describe and evaluate the viewpoints and practices of their own and other social groups, showing awareness of the implicit values on which judgments and prejudices are frequently based. **Can explain their interpretation of the cultural assumptions, preconceptions, stereotypes and prejudices of their own community and of other communities that they are familiar with. **Can interpret and explain a document or event from another culture and relate it to documents or events from their own culture(s) and/or from cultures with which they are familiar. **Can discuss the objectivity and balance of information and opinions expressed in the media about their own and other communities. Can identify and reflect on similarities and differences in culturally determined behavioural patterns (e.g. gestures and speech volume or, for sign languages, sign size) and discuss their significance in order to negotiate mutual understanding. Can, in an intercultural encounter, recognise that what one normally takes for granted in a particular situation is not necessarily shared by others, and can react and express themselves appropriately. Can generally interpret cultural cues appropriately in the culture concerned. Can reflect on and explain particular ways of communicating in their own and other cultures, and the risks of misunderstanding they generate.
B1	Can generally act according to conventions regarding posture, eye contact and distance from others. Can generally respond appropriately to the most commonly used cultural cues. Can explain features of their own culture to members of another culture or explain features of the other culture to members of their own culture. Can explain in simple terms how their own values and behaviours influence their views of other people's values and behaviours. Can discuss in simple terms the way in which things that may look "strange" to them in another sociocultural context may well be "normal" for the other people concerned. Can discuss in simple terms the way their own culturally determined actions may be perceived differently by people from other cultures.
A2	Can recognise and apply basic cultural conventions associated with everyday social exchanges (e.g. different greetings, rituals). Can act appropriately in everyday greetings, farewells and expressions of thanks and apology, although they have difficulty coping with any departure from the routine. Can recognise that their behaviour in an everyday transaction may convey a message different from the one they intend, and can try to explain this simply. Can recognise when difficulties occur in interaction with members of other cultures, even though they may not be sure how to behave in the situation.
A1	Can recognise differing ways of numbering, measuring distance, telling the time, etc. even though they may have difficulty applying this in even simple everyday transactions of a concrete type.
Pre-A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>

Descriptors marked with asterisks (**) represent a high level for B2. They may also be suitable for the C levels.